# Kpler Media Briefing

## Middle East Energy and Maritime Disruptions

*Flow data as of Saturday, 17 October 2026 (T-2, to reduce day-to-day revision noise)*

*Prepared Monday, 19 October 2026. Kpler Insight and Kpler platform data only*

## 1. Executive summary and key price drivers

Confirmed Total Hormuz Clearance was 9,867 kbd on 17 October, within a 4-day range of 9,867 kbd to 13,067 kbd. The 7-day average of 10,173 kbd sits about 41% below the pre-war baseline of 17,267 kbd. Adding Gulf of Oman terminals and the Red Sea lifts the regional 7-day average to 19,041 kbd, about 19% below its baseline. Kpler Insight reports that at least 18 vessels were reportedly attacked over 2 weeks, which keeps the risk premium intact. A Houthi strike hit the Aramco headquarters in Dhahran on 13 October, causing a fire but leaving oil operations unaffected. Meanwhile, Asian crude imports reached 26 mbd in the first half of October, within 1% of the pre-war level, as earlier Gulf cargoes arrive.

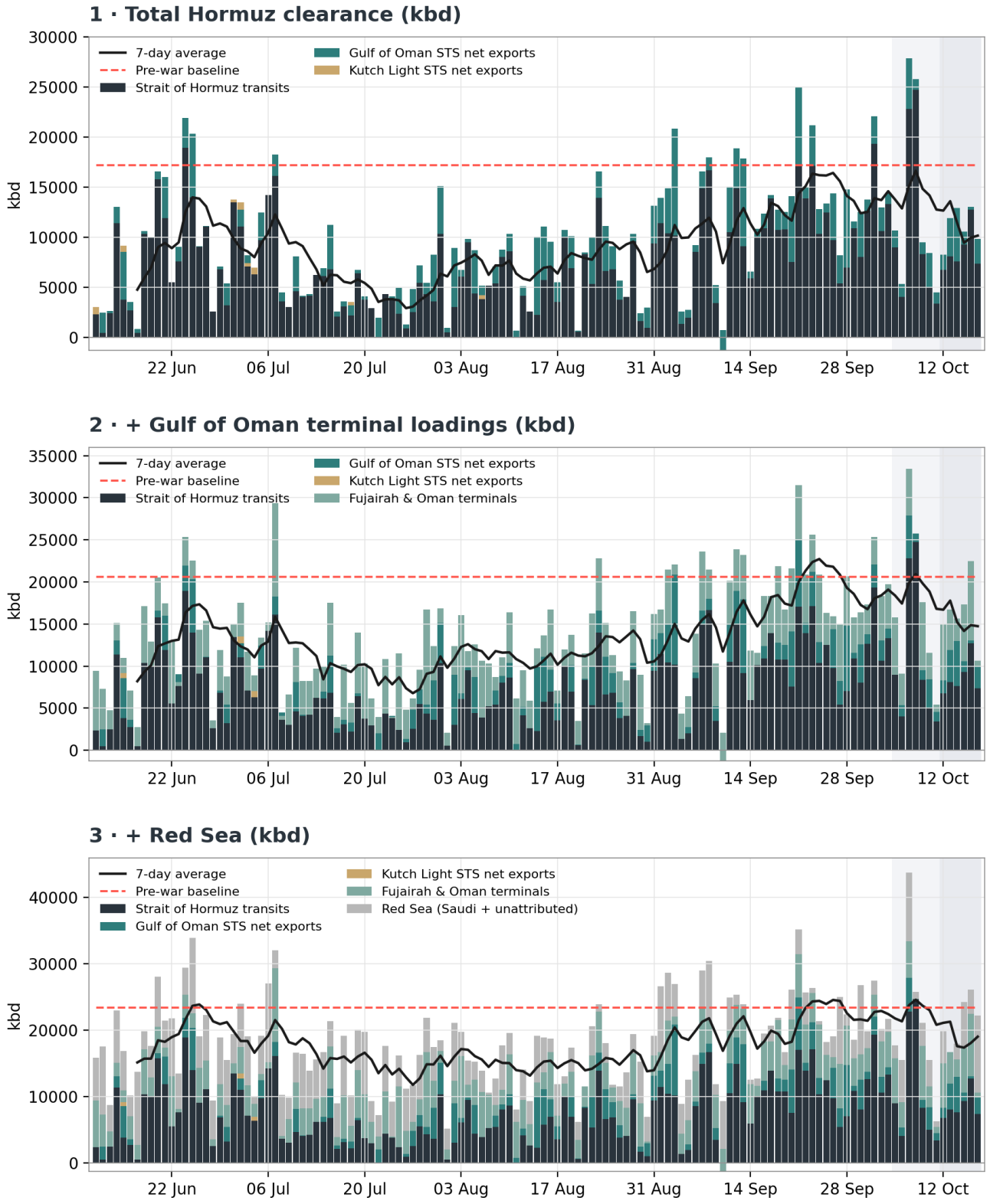
Explore these flows in the new Middle East Flows dashboard in the Kpler terminal. It brings Strait of Hormuz transits, Gulf of Oman ship-to-ship net exports and Red Sea exports together in one view.

### Middle East Regional Flows (kbd)

| Middle East Regional Flows (kbd) | 17 Oct | 16 Oct | 15 Oct | 14 Oct | 7-day MA | Pre-War Baseline |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Strait of Hormuz Transits | 7,363 | 12,739 | 9,300 | 7,621 | 7,894 | 17,267 |
| Gulf of Oman STS Net Exports | 2,504 | 328 | 1,300 | 5,327 | 2,280 | 0 |
| Kutch Light STS Net Exports | 0 | 0 | 0 | 0 | 0 | 0 |
| **1. Total Hormuz Clearance** | **9,867** | **13,067** | **10,601** | **12,948** | **10,173** | **17,267** |
| Crude | 9,363 | 11,978 | 8,925 | 12,037 | 9,094 | 13,599 |
| Products | 504 | 1,089 | 1,676 | 912 | 1,079 | 3,611 |
| Fujairah & Oman Terminals | 766 | 9,428 | 6,707 | 2,677 | 4,563 | 3,416 |
| **2. + Gulf of Oman Terminals** | **10,634** | **22,495** | **17,307** | **15,625** | **14,737** | **20,627** |
| Crude | 9,684 | 20,786 | 13,101 | 14,112 | 12,623 | 15,774 |
| Products | 949 | 1,708 | 4,207 | 1,514 | 2,113 | 4,852 |
| Red Sea (Saudi + Unattributed) | 11,585 | 3,593 | 6,919 | 2,315 | 4,304 | 2,803 |
| **3. + Red Sea** | **22,218** | **26,087** | **24,226** | **17,941** | **19,041** | **23,430** |
| Crude | 20,578 | 22,786 | 19,174 | 16,112 | 16,211 | 17,114 |
| Products | 1,640 | 3,301 | 5,052 | 1,829 | 2,830 | 6,316 |
| Strait of Hormuz Tanker Crossings | 6 | 14 | 12 | 11 | 10 | 50 |
| Enter MEG | 2 | 7 | 7 | 3 | 5 | 25 |
| Exit MEG | 4 | 7 | 5 | 8 | 5 | 25 |

*Three cumulative measures of confirmed clearance move outward from the strait itself (1) to Gulf of Oman and Fujairah/Oman terminal loadings (2) and then Red Sea volumes (3). Iranian-origin transits are excluded throughout. Figures are oil only, covering Crude/Co, CPP, DPP and Chem/Bio and excluding NGLs and LNG. Source, Kpler.*

## Middle East Regional Flows, daily series from 11 June to 17 October




*Stacked bars are the confirmed components of each cumulative measure; the solid line is the 7-day average and the dashed line the pre-war baseline. Shaded bands mark the provisional (8 to 14 days) and preliminary (last 7 days) recency tiers, which have typically settled 1.5 to 2 times higher as later confirmations land. The late-June peak reflects the evacuation of cargoes stranded by the outbreak of the war. Source, Kpler.*

### Table and chart methodology and caveats

- Every figure is a confirmed floor and can revise upward at any horizon. The recency tiers mark where revisions concentrate, not where they stop.
- Reported figures are older than 14 days, provisional figures are 8 to 14 days old, and preliminary figures cover the last 7 days. Preliminary figures have typically settled 1.5 to 2 times higher once confirmations land.
- Gulf of Oman, Kutch Light and Red Sea volumes with no confirmed load terminal capture ship-to-ship cargo net of unmatched arrivals, and they carry no origin attribution. The Iranian-origin exclusion therefore applies to strait transits only.
- Pre-war baselines are averages over March 2025 to February 2026 on the same definitions and product-bucket selection.
- Strait crossings are dated by transit, unattributed ship-to-ship cargo by the date it surfaces or departs, and berth loadings by loading date. Daily totals therefore mix event timings, and the 7-day averages absorb most of that noise.

### Primary drivers

- Attacks on commercial vessels keep clearance well below pre-war levels, and sections 2 and 3 set out the transit and fleet picture.
- Bypass routes offset part of the loss, with Fujairah and Oman terminal loadings and Red Sea volumes above their pre-war baselines (section 2).
- Saudi Arabia exports from both coasts, while Houthi strikes on Saudi sites keep the export recovery exposed (sections 3 and 4).
- Record freight lifts delivered crude costs, and Kpler expects sanctions relief for shadow fleet tankers to do little to ease it (sections 3 and 5).
- Diesel stays tight, and trend-following funds rebuilt maximum long exposure in ULSD (section 5).

## 2. Chokepoint and transit metrics

### A. Strait of Hormuz

Confirmed strait transits, excluding Iranian-origin vessels, were 7,363 kbd on 17 October. The 7-day average was 7,894 kbd, against a pre-war baseline of 17,267 kbd. Daily readings are preliminary floors and typically revise upward as confirmations land. Kpler Insight says the current decline in transits fits its view that the recovery in the strait will be uneven.

Gulf of Oman ship-to-ship net exports were 2,504 kbd on 17 October, after 328 kbd on 16 October. Their 7-day average of 2,280 kbd compares with a pre-war level of 0 kbd. Fujairah and Oman terminal loadings were 766 kbd on 17 October, after 9,428 kbd the day before. Their 7-day average of 4,563 kbd is about 34% above the pre-war baseline of 3,416 kbd. Bypass routes therefore continue to offset part of the loss at the strait.

Kpler Insight reports that Chinese buyers have secured at least 80 mb of Saudi spot crude since mid-September, while domestic stocks fall at a record pace.

### B. Bab el-Mandeb and Red Sea

Red Sea volumes were 11,585 kbd on 17 October, after 3,593 kbd on 16 October and 6,919 kbd on 15 October. The 7-day average of 4,304 kbd compares with a pre-war baseline of 2,803 kbd, about 54% above. Red Sea volumes include cargo with no confirmed load terminal, so the latest readings are preliminary. Kpler Insight reports that Sidi Kerir, the Mediterranean end of Sumed, is loading around 1 mbd, mostly bound for South Korea and Japan.

## 3. Maritime risk and fleet status

Kpler Insight reports at least 18 vessels reportedly attacked over 2 weeks, with strait tanker crossings averaging 13 a day against 50 before the war. The running week also brought the first full sinking of a vessel in about 7 months, the containership GFS PRIDE, according to IMO data cited by Kpler Insight. A Houthi strike on the Aramco administrative building in Dhahran late on Tuesday 13 October caused a fire. A source at the Saudi energy ministry confirmed there were no injuries or fatalities. Kpler reported no direct implications for oil markets, because the strike did not affect anything beyond the headquarters building.

Freight is the other pressure point. Kpler Insight reports that Middle East Gulf to China VLCC rates fell $1.09/bbl week on week to $37.37/bbl, easing from a record opening level of $38.47/bbl. More than 80 VLCCs work shuttle trades, and only around 42% of VLCCs are laden, against a 45% historical average. Kpler expects reported US sanctions relief for shadow fleet tankers to have no material impact on VLCC freight rates.

Strait tanker crossings were 6 on 17 October, against a 7-day average of 10 and a pre-war level of 50. The latest day shows 2 entries and 4 exits. Kpler classed 34 of the 43 oil tanker crossings from 14 to 17 October as dark or unknown route transits. The table shows 8 of them.

### Illustrative Mideast Gulf tanker crossings, 14 to 17 October

| Date | Vessel | Type | Direction / state | Cargo | Volume (kb) | Load port | Discharge / next port |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| 17 Oct | PERU PROSPERITY | VLCC | MEG exit, laden | Crude/Co | 2,000 | Ras Tanura, Saudi Arabia | Vadinar, India |
| 17 Oct | ARZANAH | VLCC | MEG exit, laden | Crude/Co | 1,915 | Al Basrah, Iraq | Fujairah, UAE |
| 17 Oct | CAPETAN GIANNIS | MR | MEG entry, ballast | None | 0 | Dongjiakou, China | Sohar, Oman |
| 16 Oct | BAYRAQ | VLCC | MEG exit, laden | Crude/Co | 2,000 | Ras Tanura, Saudi Arabia | Zhoushan, China |
| 16 Oct | OTTOMAN TENACITY | Suezmax | MEG entry, ballast | None | 0 | Coruna, Spain | Mina Al-Ahmadi, Kuwait |
| 15 Oct | JOURY | MR | MEG exit, laden | CPP | 316 | Jubail, Saudi Arabia | Mombasa, Kenya |
| 15 Oct | JOANNA | Small tanker | MEG exit, laden | Chemicals | 60 | Jubail, Saudi Arabia | Mumbai, India |
| 14 Oct | SEDEF | MR | MEG exit, laden | DPP | 264 | Khor Al Zubair, Iraq | Fujairah, UAE |

*Illustrative sample, not the full crossing log. Source, Kpler, Strait of Hormuz Tanker Crossings dashboard.*

Where AIS coverage lapses, Kpler applies a dark-transit methodology, cross-referencing satellite imagery and human intelligence against a binary confirmation standard before attributing a movement. See the full methodology note at the end of this briefing.

## 4. Critical infrastructure status

### Saudi infrastructure, Petroline and Yanbu

An attack on 10 September damaged a pumping station on the East-West Pipeline, also called Petroline. Kpler first assessed repairs at 4 to 6 weeks, but loadings at Yanbu and Muajjiz restarted on 17 September. Kpler analysis of satellite imagery confirmed that west coast crude loadings reached 42 mb between 17 September and 4 October. The pipeline was running at around 5.8 mbd on 12 October, according to industry sources.

The Dhahran strike underlines the exposure of Saudi infrastructure, as the Houthis continue to target sites across the kingdom. The Saudi energy ministry plans to lift pipeline capacity to 10 mbd from 7 mbd, which could take up to 3 years.

| Indicator | Latest reading |
|---|---|
| **Trigger event** | An attack on 10 September severely damaged a pumping station on Petroline. The pipeline itself appears to have sustained little damage. |
| **Pipeline status** | Running at around 5.8 mbd on 12 October, according to industry sources, against 5.4 to 5.5 mbd before the attack. |
| **Restoration timeline** | Kpler first assessed repairs at 4 to 6 weeks. Loadings at Yanbu and Muajjiz restarted on 17 September, and the pipeline was operational by at least 22 September. |
| **Estimated export exposure** | In early September Petroline carried around 1.8 mbd of refinery feedstock and 3.6 mbd of Yanbu loadings. The Kpler base case at half throughput cut Yanbu exports by 2.5 to 2.7 mbd. |
| **Yanbu terminal inventories** | Kpler assessed Yanbu oil terminal stocks at 9 mb and other west coast refinery stocks at 16.5 mb on 14 September. West coast crude inventories reached 16.17 mb on 4 October. |
| **Grade mix effect** | Petroline feeds roughly 1.5 mbd of mainly Arab Light and Arab Heavy to western refineries. Asian refiners short of Arab grades were expected to substitute other sour grades before Atlantic Basin sweet grades. |
| **East coast pivot** | Ras Tanura exports surged to 2.99 mbd in the week to 20 September, while Yanbu exports fell to 429 kbd from 3.98 mbd in the week to 6 September. Saudi Arabia is expected to keep exporting from both coasts. |

*Sources, Kpler Insight publications dated 11 September, 14 September, 22 September, 5 October and 12 October 2026.*

## 5. Refined products and bunker fuel impact

Diesel stays the tightest part of the barrel. Gasoil rose 9.5% in the week to 9 October against 2.4% for Brent, after EU states declined to add to March stock releases. Kpler Insight attributes the move to policy rather than new demand and estimates the global diesel deficit at around 1 mbd as peak seasonal demand begins. A US authorisation of Russian diesel imports came too late to change the weekly print, and nearly 40% of Russian refining capacity is idle.

Trend-following CTAs bought about 2.8 mb of ULSD in the reporting week from 6 to 13 October, returning to 100% long for the first time since 24 September. ULSD rose 8% week on week, with US Gulf Coast diesel cracks up $9.78/bbl. Gasoline fundamentals softened, and trend-following CTAs cut RBOB exposure from 91% to 82% long.

Fuel oil also stays tight. Singapore fuel oil rose 7.4% as scarce cutter stocks kept high sulphur fuel oil in backwardation. Kpler Insight expects Singapore HSFO to stay supported until Russian and Middle Eastern arrivals in late October test the backwardation.

Clean freight added to the squeeze, as LR2 tankers switched to more lucrative dirty cargoes. LR2 rates from the Middle East Gulf to Japan rose $1.5/bbl month on month to $24.96/bbl, and Kpler Insight sees further upside for clean freight from the region.

| Benchmark | Weekly move | Note |
|---|---|---|
| **Brent** | +2.4% | A modest rise despite the headlines. Brent retreated once Washington ruled out strikes on Iran before the US midterm elections. |
| **WTI** | +0.8% | Lagged Brent because US buffers are deeper and Gulf platforms restarted quickly after Hurricane Isaias. |
| **Gasoil** | +9.5% | Led the complex on policy rather than new demand, after EU states declined to add to March stock releases. |
| **Singapore fuel oil** | +7.4% | Scarce cutter stocks kept high sulphur fuel oil in backwardation. |
| **Naphtha NWE** | +5.7% | Low ARA stocks and higher delivered freight. |
| **RBOB** | −0.5% | US gasoline yields recovered and supply lengthened into winter. |

*Source, Kpler Insight, Cross Commodity Weekly, published 13 October 2026 and covering the week to 9 October, based on Marketview pricing data.*

## 6. Sources and notes

This briefing draws exclusively on Kpler Insight research and Kpler platform data. No external or third-party sources were used.

### Kpler Insight citations


- Matt Wright and Panagiotis Krontiras, “Atlantic dirty market eases as freight costs weigh on Asian buying”, Tankers Weekly, published 16 October 2026. https://terminal.kpler.com/insight/research/reports/atlantic-dirty-market-eases-as-freight-costs-weigh-on-asian-buying
- Florian Grünberger, “CTAs return to max long in ULSD while trimming gasoline longs”, Market Positioning Weekly, published 17 October 2026. https://terminal.kpler.com/insight/research/reports/ctas-return-to-max-long-in-ulsd-while-trimming-gasoline-longs
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- Homayoun Falakshahi, “Saudi Arabia’s last exit narrows, reported Petroline strike meets Houthi control of Bab el-Mandeb”, Market Pulse, published 11 September 2026. https://terminal.kpler.com/insight/research/research-updates/saudi-arabia-s-last-exit-narrows-reported-petroline-strike-meets-houthi-control-of-bab-el-mandeb

## Kpler platform data

- Kpler Insight search API (reports and short-form content), published-by-date range from 16 October to 19 October 2026. Uses a 48-hour rolling window on Wednesday to Friday editions, extended back to the prior Friday on Monday and Tuesday editions to include weekend publications.
- Kpler internal flow-tracking data, “Middle East Regional Flows” measures (Total Hormuz Clearance and Strait of Hormuz Tanker Crossings panel), flow data to 17 October 2026, compiled by the Insight team.
- Kpler, Strait of Hormuz Tanker Crossings dashboard, illustrative vessel sample, 14 to 17 October 2026.

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## Standing methodology note, vessel and cargo tracking

Kpler compiles vessel and cargo tracking data from 3 complementary sources. Automatic Identification System (AIS) signals form the backbone, providing real-time position data whenever a vessel's transponder is active. A gap in that signal is informative but not conclusive on its own. Satellite imagery, both optical and synthetic aperture radar (SAR), corroborates vessel presence and laden state at terminals and along transit routes. SAR can see through cloud cover where optical imagery cannot. These streams are supplemented by human intelligence, meaning market sources reporting loading events, ship-to-ship transfer scheduling and port call activity. This intelligence often flags a movement before satellite imagery can confirm it.

The 3 streams are cross-referenced against a binary confirmation standard. An event is recorded only when consistent evidence from more than one source supports it, not through probabilistic attribution or a single source. Where AIS coverage lapses, such as during a dark transit, analysts look for satellite imagery placing a vessel inside a region on one date and outside it on another. They also draw on human intelligence and discharge-side confirmation that corroborates timing and cargo grade. Volumes that cannot be independently verified this way are classified as unknown origin rather than attributed by inference, a deliberately conservative approach that favours accuracy over completeness.

*Source, Middle East and Gulf of Oman dark crude exports methodology, Kpler Help Centre. https://help.kpler.com/en/articles/15462913-middle-east-and-gulf-of-oman-dark-crude-exports-methodology*